

Input Devices

Input devices consist of keyboards, joysticks and mice. The market is full of a wide variety of products, and deciding which one is right for you can be confusing.

You can buy a cheap, no-frills keyboard that is sturdy, and does the job at a rock-bottom price of Rs 300. There are several kinds to choose from, including regular 104-key PS/2 keyboards and newer cordless models that use radio waves or infrared rays to communicate with the computer. Due to their increasing popularity, these are now available in a price range of Rs 1,500 to Rs 1,800.

Mice, like keyboards, have so many options that it is hard to choose one—from simple scroll mice to optical, infrared, multiple-buttoned beauties that will leave you drooling. The prices range from Rs 300 to several thousand rupees.

The three primary types of game controllers—wheels, joysticks and game pads—are individually suited to a certain game genres. A joystick is the ideal controller for flight simulators, while game pads and wheels are better suited for driving games. However, most first-person action games are still best played with a combination of a keyboard and mouse. Microsoft and Logitech might be the big boys, but a lot of other smaller brands such as JS Equipments have solid, reliable units as well. An exciting feature found in high-end devices is force feedback—this adds considerable realism to game playing in arcade, driving and flight simulation games.

Technology Insight

The flat QWERTY layout is the most popular, but some people prefer more ergonomic models. The Natural and split keyboards from Microsoft are examples of these.

Most mice use a roller-ball mechanism to track horizontal and vertical movement. Some mice use an optical motion tracking system instead of the ball. These use a beam of light reflected off the work surface to track movement.

Smart Tips

Ergonomics (and Weight): For any input device, the most important factor is the way it feels. This is a combination of the weight, balance and the placement of buttons. A badly designed device can cause discomfort and, in some cases, even Tendonitis.

Useless features: Quality comes before quantity. Before being overwhelmed by the number of buttons or features, see that the device fits your needs, and is comfortable.

Configuration and Drivers: While a lot of these devices will work with the generic drivers supplied with Windows, device-specific drivers will allow you to calibrate and optimise your device's performance.

Connector: USB devices are becoming increasingly popular. They are easy to install and have better reaction times.

Efficiency: Scroll wheels, hotkeys, hat switches, throttle controls, etc., are all nifty little add-ons to these devices that will make using them a snap.

Decision Maker

	Keyboards		Mice		Game Controllers	
	Low budget	No budget	Low budget	No budget	Low budget	No budget
You need	A cheap and long lasting solution	The ultimate in comfort and good looks	A cheap yet comfortable mouse	Extreme precision and supreme comfort	A satisfactory gaming experience at minimal cost	A joystick that lets you feel the action
Look for	104 keys, membrane type, PS/2 interface	Ergonomic, a PS/2 or USB interface, palm rest, hot keys	Scroll mouse with PS/2 interface, preferably optical	Optical scroll mouse, extra programmable buttons, PS/2, USB	Two axis, 4 button, with a Gameport or USB interface	Three axis, 8 button, force feedback, with a USB interface
Our pick	Samsung SEM-DT35N	Microsoft Multimedia Keyboard	Benq M100 Optical Mouse	Logitech MX500 Optical Mouse	Typhoon 3D Joystick	Microsoft Side Winder Force Feedback 2
Price range	Upto Rs 300	Upto Rs 1,300	Upto Rs 700	Upto Rs 5,000	Upto Rs 1,000	Upto Rs 8,000